

SHOW OF STRENGTH Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray with candidate Chandrahar Patil in Sangli

BATTLE OF PATILS

Will the Congress-Shiv Sena (UBT) fracas over Sangli impact the prospects of the MVA in Maharashtra and the pan-nation interests of the I.N.D.I.A. bloc?

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

gress stronghold, proved to hold more twists than a river in the Ghats has. It was the political homestead of the late party stalwart and chief minister Vasantrao Patil (a.k.a. Vasantdada). Between 1980, when Vasantdada was first elected to the Lok Sabha, and 2014, when the Modi wave swept through these parts, Sangli had sent a member of Vasantdada's family to Parliament each election—be it his wife Shalinitai, son Prakashbapu, nephew Madan (son of Vasantrao's cousin Vishwanathrao a.k.a. Vishnuanna) or grandson Pratik. The last named was a Union minister of state in 2014 when he had the mortification of seeing this party and family bastion breached by BJP's Sanjaykaka Patil. In 2019, Sanjaykaka trounced Pratik's brother Vishal to be re-elected from the seat. The BJP is betting on its man pulling off a hat-trick this time, while the Congress was hoping to reclaim its old bastion this year with a repeat attempt by Vishal—buoyed by pooled MVA votes. However, the Uddhav Sena didn't wait for the starting gun and announced Chandrahar Patil, a wrestler and two-time winner of the prestigious 'Maharashtra Kesari' title, as its candidate from the seat. The unilateral move naturally upset local Congress worthies and a delegation of state leaders met senior leader K.C. Venugopal in New Delhi on March 27 to assert their claim to the seat.

ALLIES CONGRESS & SHIV SENA (UBT) ARE BOTH STAKING CLAIM TO SANGLI, SEEKING TO NOMINATE THEIR OWN CANDIDATES FROM HERE

The Uddhav Sena's claim over Sangli comes as a surprise to everyone across parties, as it has a less-than-marginal presence in the district. Congress leaders claim that of the 600-odd villages in the constituency, the Sena (UBT) does not have sarpanches (village heads) in even 10. Also, while Chandrahar is a former member of the Sangli zilla parishad and despite the popularity wrestling enjoys in the region, plenty of MVA leaders doubt his capacity to pin Sanjaykaka down to the mat.

But there are wheels within wheels. Inside sources let on that the Sena (UBT) was egged on to stake a claim to the Sangli seat by Jayant Patil, former Maharashtra cabinet minister and state unit chief of the NCP (Sharad Pawar). Jayant's family has traditionally been at odds with the Vasantdada clan, since the days of his father Rajarambapu Patil, over control of local politics. Jayant is said to be eager to launch his son, also named Pratik, in electoral politics, and infusing a little confusion among potential rivals reportedly helps his future plans. However, speaking to INDIA TODAY, NCP (Sharad Pawar) spokesperson Clyde Crasto denied the party or any of its leaders had played a role in the Congress-Sena (UBT) fracas in Sangli. "This is absolutely wrong. There is no truth in that. We are together as the MVA and the I.N.D.I.A. alliance. These are rumours being spread by those